ABSTRACT

This is an exploratory essay about epistemological horror, which can be understood broadly as horror fiction that engages with epistemological questions, and more narrowly as horror fiction that engages with questions about the boundaries of human knowledge. It is suggested that there are at least two interesting categories of epistemological horror. One relates to the question of *what should and should not be known*, while the other relates to the question of *what can and cannot be known*. These categories can be broken down further into the categories of Promethean, Cartesian, and Lovecraftian epistemological horror. After explaining and investigating these categories of epistemological horror, I briefly consider the idea that horror fiction has epistemological value. Throughout the essay, I offer some thoughts about the general nature of horror fiction and the alleged paradox of horror fiction.

I. INTRODUCTION

Many subgenres of horror fiction are widely recognized, including supernatural horror, body horror, folk horror, cosmic horror, psychological horror, and so on. Here I want to recognize a subgenre that has not been the focus of much philosophical attention despite being of particular philosophical interest. I have in mind *epistemological horror*, which can be understood broadly as horror fiction that engages with epistemological questions, and more narrowly as horror fiction that engages with questions about the boundaries of human knowledge. My goal is to taxonomize and explain some varieties of epistemological horror (though not necessarily *all* varieties of epistemological horror). It is suggested that there are at least two interesting categories. One relates to the question of *what should and should not be known*, while the other relates to the question of *what can and cannot be known*. This essay is exploratory in spirit, so it is intended to provide a starting point for further development and discussion. It is my hope that it might contribute

something somewhat new to the philosophy of horror, which has concentrated mostly on the nature of horror (*what are the essential characteristics of horror fiction?*) and the paradox of horror (*why do people enjoy horror fiction?*). Neither problem is my main concern, though I consider the first problem in section II, and I share some thoughts about the second problem throughout the essay. In sections III and IV, I explain in more detail the two categories of epistemological horror that I mentioned above. In my concluding section, I briefly consider the idea that horror fiction has epistemological value.

II. THE NATURE OF HORROR

Though my main concern is not to propose a philosophically insightful definition of horror fiction, it is worth our time to discuss the nature of horror fiction generally before investigating epistemological horror specifically. The most rigorous attempt to define horror fiction is perhaps Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990), where horror fiction is treated as fiction designed to horrify through the depiction of monsters, and where monsters are understood as beings that do not currently exist according to science.[1] Carroll proceeds to analyze the emotion of horror as involving fear, elicited by the fact that the monster is threatening, and also disgust, elicited by the fact that the monster is categorically impure, violating the conceptual schemes that are learned from culture and employed to understand the world.[2]

The most obvious objection to Carroll's theory is that there are examples of horror fiction that do not involve monsters in Carroll's sense. These include certain "slashers" and "creature features," such as *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*, *Halloween*, *Jaws*, and *Crawl*, among many others. In defense of his theory, Carroll points out that some of these alleged counterexamples involve beings that seem to possess characteristics that would qualify them as monsters in his sense (1990, 37). For example, Michael Myers from the *Halloween* franchise sometimes seems to be

supernaturally impervious to harm. Carroll relegates other alleged counterexamples to other genres of fiction, such as suspense, which he regards as distinct from horror (1990, 38–42). But, unfortunately for Carroll, some of these films, such as *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*, are central examples of horror fiction, hardly negotiable borderline cases. Or consider the original *Halloween*. Sure, whether Michael Myers has supernatural powers is open to interpretation, and may depend on how we understand the final sequence of the film, but whether *Halloween* is horror fiction is not ambiguous in the same way. The film is a paradigmatic example of horror fiction and we do not need to wait until the end of the film in order to appreciate it as such. The mere fact that Carroll's theory struggles to accommodate *Halloween* is worrisome.

It might be tempting to redefine the term "monster" in order to avoid the above objection. However, it is somewhat dubious whether horror fiction must include monsters in *any* sense. Indeed, it is somewhat dubious whether Carroll's "entity-based" approach to horror fiction can survive counterexamples. He himself mentions Guy De Maupassant's "Who Knows?" and several other stories that do not seem organized in any significant way around any entity, much less a monster (1990, 41–42). Instead, these stories seem to form an "event-based" category of horror fiction. Carroll ultimately recommends that these stories be classified as "tales of dread" rather than horror fiction. But, given their prevalence in anthologies of classic horror stories, it is at least debatable whether horror fiction must involve monsters. And even if attention is restricted to horror fiction that involves monsters in Carroll's sense, there is a potential problem with his characterization of the emotion that horror fiction is designed to elicit. Recall that Carroll describes this emotion as essentially involving both fear and disgust. But consider killer dolls and puppets, such as those depicted in *Child's Play* and *Puppet Master*. These things are certainly common in horror fiction, and they certainly inspire fear by virtue of being threatening, but are they necessarily

disgusting, gross, repulsive, or revolting? I submit that, though we do not want to go near these things for obvious reasons, we do not necessarily find them to be disgusting, at least in the ordinary sense of the word—rather they are disturbing, unsettling, or creepy.

In any event, it seems to me that we would do well to consider a more expansive view of horror fiction and the responses that horror fiction is designed to elicit. Hick (2022) maintains that horror fiction is designed to elicit a wide variety of negative affects. These include emotions, such as fear, which may focus on entities in horror fiction but which may also focus on events. They also include moods, such as dread, which may not focus on anything in particular (Freeland 2004; Sauchelli 2014). Also included are feelings related to cosmic terror (Lovecraft 2008/1927), abjection (Kristeva 1982/1980; Creed 1993), and the uncanny (Jentsch 2008/1906; Freud 2003/1919), the last of which is often invoked in order to explain the vague sense that something is disturbing, unsettling, or creepy. At this point, it would be reasonable to ask whether there is anything that these different affects have in common such as that we associate each of them with this specific genre of fiction. Unfortunately, the answer to this question is not simply that these affects are each negative in nature. For, as Hick understands (2022, 146), there are many negative affects that are not necessarily associated with horror fiction, including sadness, anger, jealousy, embarrassment, and so on. But, regardless of whether there is a principled answer to the above question, it must be admitted that Hick's account seems descriptively adequate, capturing the sort of fiction that is intuitively classified as horror. Though most of the fiction cited in this essay would count as horror according to Carroll, there are occasional references to fiction that would not count as horror according to Carroll but would count according to Hick's more pluralistic conception of the genre.[3]

With this conception in mind, I want to investigate the subgenre of epistemological horror fiction. It is agreed by both Carroll and Hick that horror fiction is characterized by the responses that it is designed to elicit. Epistemological horror fiction, I submit, is characterized by the way in which it is designed to elicit those responses. Horror fiction counts as epistemological horror fiction if it is designed to elicit those responses partly by engaging with an epistemological question—in other words, if the relevant affect, whether fear or dread or whatever, is grounded in something that relates directly to an epistemological question. When I speak of epistemological questions, I speak of general philosophical questions about knowledge. To my mind, the most salient epistemological questions to be found in horror fiction are concerned with the boundaries of human knowledge (*what, generally speaking, are the boundaries of human knowledge?*). A few clarifications are now in order. First, I am open to the possibility that horror fiction sometimes engages with other epistemological questions. Indeed, epistemology as an academic discipline often engages with other questions. But even if horror fiction sometimes engages with other epistemological questions, it engages much more frequently and substantively with questions about the boundaries of human knowledge, or so I contend. Second, I want to construe "boundaries" in a broad way. There are boundaries that we can cross and there are boundaries that we cannot cross. But even if the boundary is one that we *can* cross, there is a significant sense in which we *should not* cross it—crossing it would constitute a transgression, a trespass, a violation. Boundaries of this kind, to be discussed in section III, are associated with forbidden knowledge, or *what should not be known*. Boundaries of the other kind, to be discussed in section IV, are associated with *what cannot be known*. These correspond to two separate, but not mutually exclusive, categories of epistemological horror fiction. Roughly, the first category can be understood as involving an improper excess of knowledge and the second can be understood as

involving a troubling deficiency of knowledge. To anticipate, paradigmatic examples of the first category include Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* and paradigmatic examples of the second include Wes Craven's *A Nightmare on Elm Street*.[4]

III. WHAT SHOULD NOT BE KNOWN?

Aristotle opined that all men by nature desire to know. And indeed curiosity lies at the heart of many horror stories. Intriguingly, Carroll argues that curiosity is the key to solving the paradox of horror (1990, 158–195). On his view, horror fiction is fascinating precisely because of the way that it depicts the discovery of monsters, engaging the curiosity of the characters and thereby engaging our curiosity. Now, as a general solution to the paradox of horror, this proposal is questionable for several reasons. One is that it relies on Carroll's theory that horror fiction always involves monsters, which, as argued in section II, is disputable. Another reason is that it does not explain why we might enjoy horror stories but not mystery stories, which also seek to engage curiosity. Carroll seems to suggest that the sort of curiosity invoked by horror fiction is qualitatively different by virtue of the conceptually impure nature of monsters (1990, 191), but this idea is not fleshed out. Yet another worry is that Carroll's proposal does not explain why we might want to rewatch a horror film or reread a horror novel, even when we still remember the revealing of the monster. If our enjoyment of horror fiction were due mainly to curiosity about the monster, then this behavior would be difficult to understand. Finally, Carroll holds that the emotion of horror is merely "part of the price to be paid" in order to satiate our curiosity about the monster (1990, 184). But, as Susan Feagin (1992) has stressed, this idea is counterintuitive. Horror fans often *want* to be scared and grossed out by horror fiction. That is seemingly part of the fun.[5]

Still, Carroll is undoubtedly correct that curiosity plays a significant role in horror fiction. For present purposes, it would be fruitful to focus more on the curiosity that leads characters to

create, discover, or release monsters. The first masterpiece of horror fiction is arguably Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*. It involves what Carroll calls an "overreacher plot" (1990, 118). The mad scientist Victor Frankenstein seeks to identify the secret of life and create an artificial man. When Frankenstein succeeds, his creation is seen as monstrous and eventually endeavors to destroy Frankenstein's life. One of the central themes of the novel, anticipated in the Greek myth of Prometheus and the biblical tale of Eden, is someone's attempt to gain forbidden knowledge, which results in horrifyingly destructive consequences. In honor of the Greek myth, as well as the alternate title of Shelley's novel, let us refer to this variety of epistemological horror fiction as *Promethean epistemological horror*. It is designed to horrify (where "horrify" is understood in the broad sense suggested in section II) partly by depicting characters who seek forbidden knowledge, resulting in destructive consequences. In contrast with philosophical traditions that regard knowledge as empowering and liberating ("Knowledge is power," said Francis Bacon), this variety of horror fiction suggests a pessimistic attitude toward the value of knowledge. It is Promethean epistemological horror that Chloe Buckley has in mind when she writes that "epistemological horror posits knowledge as disastrous rather than empowering" (2017, 20). I would add that paradigmatic examples of Promethean epistemological horror are stories where the destructive consequences that befall the characters are represented as retribution for the pursuit of forbidden knowledge. As Cynthia Freeland writes in her analysis of the *Frankenstein* story: "The author clearly implies that Frankenstein has overstepped the bounds of Nature, has peered too closely into Her secrets; in this and similar cases, Nature strikes back, and She is sublime and forceful" (2002, 35).

Thus, paradigmatic examples of Promethean epistemological horror are functioning as morality plays or cautionary tales. The characters are depicted as crossing a boundary that they

should not cross and horror ensues as a sort of retribution. This variety of epistemological horror is ubiquitous in the genre. It is found in everything from the classic Universal Studios adaptation of *Frankenstein* (where Frankenstein infamously declares "Now I know what it feels like to be God!") to the hilariously terrible Ed Wood film *Bride of the Monster* (where one of the characters says "He tampered in God's domain" in reaction to the death of the mad scientist). Paradigmatic examples are stories where characters create monsters through their misplaced curiosity and these monsters serve as agents of retribution. However, not every example of a genre needs to be a paradigmatic example. It is possible that pure curiosity is not the driving force of the character who creates the monster. The motivation could be more practical—perhaps to use the monster as a weapon. Furthermore, it is possible that the monster is released rather than created and that the characters who suffer as a result are not the ones ultimately responsible for the release of the monster. Thus, films such as *Alien* arguably count as Promethean epistemological horror, or at least as having themes of Promethean epistemological horror. In that film, the crew of the spaceship *Nostromo* is directed by corporate bosses to acquire a dangerous alien from a mysterious planet for the purposes of weaponizing it. The alien, of course, is released on the spaceship and the crew is almost entirely killed as a result. Here the monster is the object of curiosity—the corporation wishes to know whether it can be weaponized. It might happen, though, that the monster is created or released without being the object of curiosity. It might happen, in other words, that the monster is created or released as a mere side effect of someone seeking knowledge. Thus, films such as the original *Godzilla* and even *Night of the Living Dead* have themes of Promethean epistemological horror. In the former film, it is suggested that the monster was drawn from the depths of the ocean because of hydrogen bomb testing. The monster thus represents the potentially destructive consequences of scientific inquiry. In the latter film, it is suggested that the

cannibalistic ghouls were created by radiation from a Venus space probe that exploded in Earth's atmosphere. It would have been understood in the 1960s that Venus space probes are Russian in origin. Thus, the implication of the film is that the United States military destroyed the Russian probe as it entered Earth's atmosphere. As Joe Bob Briggs says in his commentary on the film: "So you have Russia trying to mess with Nature, you have the United States trying to mess with Russia, and that ends up being a cosmic situation with unintended consequences. Everybody trying to play God and God saying *Well actually guys, this is what happens when you do that*."[6]

Promethean epistemological horror is most commonly and perhaps most naturally found in science fiction horror, but it can be found in other genres as well. Buckley (2017) has discussed themes of Promethean epistemological horror in gothic children's literature (though Buckley does not use the term "Promethean"), where the forbidden knowledge is not depicted as being naturalistic or scientific. Instead, the forbidden knowledge is occult in essence. And arguably there are themes of Promethean epistemological horror in Clive Barker's *Hellraiser*, based on his novella *The Hellbound Heart*. Interestingly, the knowledge being sought in this case is not factual or propositional knowledge. Unlike the mad scientist Victor Frankenstein, the obsessive hedonist Frank Cotton does not wish to gain some piece of information. Instead, he wishes to experience pleasures that he has not yet experienced. Thus, the knowledge being sought is *acquaintance* knowledge rather than factual or propositional knowledge. And, of course, Frank's desire to become acquainted with new pleasures results in gory catastrophe when he summons the sadomasochistic Cenobites.[7]

IV. WHAT CANNOT BE KNOWN?

General questions about what can or cannot be known are often framed in terms of *skepticism*. A skeptic is someone who denies or doubts that one can know things with respect to a certain domain.

There are therefore many forms of skepticism, depending on the relevant domain, but one of the most widely discussed forms of skepticism is *external world skepticism*. An external world skeptic denies or doubts that one can know things with respect to the external world—the physical world that supposedly exists outside our minds. What makes external world skepticism so philosophically interesting is that there are compelling arguments in its favor. These arguments will often invoke *skeptical scenarios*—hypothetical scenarios in which we are having the same perceptual experiences that we are having right now, but in which those perceptual experiences misrepresent reality. For example, it might seem obvious to me, based on my current perceptual experiences, that there is a coffee mug in front of me, but an external world skeptic might call this belief into question by invoking a skeptical scenario—for example, how am I able to rule out the possibility that I am merely dreaming that there is a coffee mug in front of me? In this scenario, I am having the same perceptual experiences, but they are misleading and my belief that there is a coffee mug in front of me is false.[8]

Here the external world skeptic is relying on the classic distinction between appearance and reality—it might *appear* that some proposition about the external world is true, but it does not follow that the proposition is *really* true. How, we might wonder, can we know that appearance corresponds to reality? To the external world skeptic, the boundary between appearance and reality is uncrossable. External world skepticism in the Western philosophical tradition is closely associated with René Descartes, who sought to identify beliefs that are not susceptible to rational doubt (1996/1641). In his pursuit of such knowledge, he famously raised various skeptical scenarios, including the dream scenario mentioned above. He also raised a skeptical scenario that is much more radical, even horrifying. According to this scenario, the only things that exist are myself, as a disembodied spirit, and a powerful demon who seeks to deceive me. All my current

perceptual experiences are conjured by this demon. They do not correspond to anything in the physical world. Indeed, according to this skeptical scenario, there is no physical world. In this respect, the scenario is even more radical than skeptical scenarios wherein I am a brain in a vat whose perceptual experiences are products of a powerful computer simulation (Putnam 1981).

A few points of clarification. First, the external world skeptic need not insist that such scenarios are true. The point of invoking them is to undermine the idea that we know even basic things about the external world.[9] Second, I said above that Descartes is closely associated with external world skepticism, but he was not himself an external world skeptic. Though he took skeptical scenarios seriously, he ultimately argued that they could be ruled out and that we are generally justified in trusting our perceptual experiences. Of course, Descartes's argument against external world skepticism is highly controversial, which brings me to my third point of clarification—we are not here interested in debating whether external world skepticism is correct. There are many strategies that we might pursue against skepticism, including Descartes's, but our focus is horror fiction. The question, then, is whether there is horror fiction that engages substantively with questions about the boundary between appearance and reality, and the answer to this question is affirmative.

Let us say that *Cartesian epistemological horror* is designed to horrify (where, again, "horrify" is construed broadly) partly by depicting its characters as having perceptual experiences that potentially misrepresent reality. An example is Wes Craven's *A Nightmare on Elm Street*, which deftly exploits the distinction between appearance and reality by having Freddy Krueger assail his victims in their dreams. The film's effectiveness as horror fiction is grounded partly in the fact that Freddy's victims cannot trust that their perceptual experiences accurately represent reality. Instead, Freddy might be manipulating those perceptual experiences in such a way that

they misrepresent reality. This is scary because it makes the characters vulnerable to attack, but it is also troubling because it raises skeptical worries about our knowledge of the external world. The epistemological theme of the film is articulated explicitly by the high school teacher when she says, "What is seen is not always what is real." This theme is evident in various scenes, such as when Freddy lures Tina into an alley outside her house. As he attacks her, it is revealed to the audience that she is still in bed with her boyfriend and immersed in a dream that Freddy has conjured. The boyfriend wakes as Tina is eviscerated by an unseen force. Freddy is threatening both physically and epistemologically.

In films such as *A Nightmare on Elm Street*, there is an identifiable supernatural monster who undermines the reliability of a character's perceptual experiences. This, however, is not essential to Cartesian epistemological horror. The reliability of a character's perceptual experiences might be undermined as a result of more realistic psychological disturbances, relating to grief (as suggested in *Smile*), abuse (as suggested in "The Yellow Wallpaper"), paranoia (as suggested in *Bug*), or something else entirely. Furthermore, skeptical worries in *A Nightmare on Elm Street* are raised early and recur throughout the film. This happens in paradigmatic examples of Cartesian epistemological horror, but again it is not essential. In some cases, the possibility that appearance does not correspond to reality is not salient until later in the story (spoiler alert—*Carnival of Souls*, *Jacob's Ladder*, *High Tension* and many other horror films fall into this category).

Note that there is considerable overlap between Cartesian epistemological horror and what is sometimes known simply as *psychological* horror. I would say that Jennifer Kent's *The Babadook*, for example, falls into both genres, since it engages substantively with psychological themes relating to trauma, loss, familial bonds, and so on. But I do not believe that the genres are

coextensive. It would be a stretch to describe *A Nightmare on Elm Street*, for example, as psychological horror. Regardless, there are instances of psychological horror that do not count as Cartesian epistemological horror, such as Edgar Ulmer's *The Black Cat*, Thomas Harris's *The Silence of the Lambs*, Ari Aster's *Hereditary*, and Stephen King's *Misery*.

Lovecraftian horror is also sometimes associated with epistemological horror, so it is worth our time to explore the connections between these two genres as well. The former genre is usually characterized in terms of its trappings or its themes. The trappings of Lovecraftian horror include anything that belongs distinctively to the "Cthulhu Mythos" that H. P. Lovecraft created—the Old Ones, the Deep Ones, the *Necronomicon* of Abdul Alhazred, and so on. The themes include pessimism concerning both the significance of human existence and the scope of human understanding. If we set aside the trappings of Lovecraftian horror and focus exclusively on its themes, then it is fair to identify Lovecraftian horror with *cosmic* horror. It is this kind of Lovecraftian horror, emphasizing humanity's unimportance and ignorance, that some writers seem to have in mind when they identify epistemological horror with Lovecraftian horror (Secundus 2020; Jokisch 2020). But the relationship between epistemological horror and Lovecraftian horror, even in the narrow sense of cosmic horror, is not so straightforward. In the first place, Promethean epistemological horror, such as *Frankenstein*, need not be Lovecraftian even in the narrow sense. In the second place, though Cartesian epistemological horror involves similar themes concerning the scope of human understanding, it is not essentially connected to any view concerning the significance of human existence. Suppose, then, that we focus exclusively on the aspect of Lovecraftian horror that emphasizes the limited scope of human understanding. Is it fair to identify Lovecraftian horror, in this even *narrower* sense, with Cartesian epistemological horror?

My view is that there is an interesting variety of epistemological horror that we can fairly call "Lovecraftian," but it should be distinguished from Cartesian epistemological horror. Though both subgenres are underwritten by skepticism concerning human knowledge, these skepticisms differ in key respects. The external world skepticism associated with Cartesian epistemological horror is largely a matter of whether our perceptual experiences are misrepresenting reality—for example, this sort of skepticism calls into question my belief that there is a coffee mug in front of me by raising the possibility that I am dreaming. The sort of skepticism suggested in Lovecraft's work is roughly summarized in his short story "From Beyond," concerning the mad scientist Crawford Tillinghast. "What do we know," Tillinghast asks "of the world and the universe about us? Our means of receiving impressions are absurdly few, and our notions of surrounding objects infinitely narrow. We see things only as we are constructed to see them, and can gain no idea of their absolute nature. With five feeble senses we pretend to comprehend the boundlessly complex cosmos, yet other beings with a wider, stronger, or different range of senses might not only see very differently the things we see, but might see and study whole worlds of matter, energy, and life which lie close at hand yet can never be detected with the senses we have" (2008/1934, 116). It is revealed that Tillinghast has discovered a means of accessing a nightmarish plane of existence that somehow coincides with our own and yet harbors hideous monsters. What is important to recognize about this story is that, unlike Cartesian epistemological horror, it does not raise the frightening possibility that our perceptual experiences are *illusory* in the sense that they misrepresent reality. There is no suggestion that we might merely be dreaming of the physical objects that we standardly take ourselves to perceive. Tillinghast might be perfectly willing to agree that there is a coffee mug in front of me just as there appears to be a coffee mug in front of me. Instead, the story raises the frightening possibility that our perceptual experiences are

inadequate in the sense that they are constitutively incapable of detecting certain fundamental features of reality. There is also the suggestion in Lovecraft's work that our cognitive faculties are constitutively incapable of even comprehending certain fundamental features of reality.

Let us say that a certain feature of reality is *perceptually hidden* from a thing if that thing's perceptual faculties are not adequate to perceive that feature of reality. Furthermore, a certain feature of reality is *cognitively hidden* from a thing if that thing's conceptual faculties are not adequate to comprehend that feature of reality.[10] It is believed that some insects perceive only two dimensions, in which case the third dimension of space is perceptually hidden from them. Lovecraftian horror fiction often invokes the idea that there are fundamental features of reality that are similarly hidden from humans. Of course, some features of reality might be perceptually hidden but not cognitively hidden from humans—perhaps the existence of electrons is an example. But Lovecraftian horror fiction also often invokes the idea that there are fundamental features of reality that are cognitively hidden from humans, in the same way that the existence of electrons is cognitively hidden from other creatures—even the cleverest dog is incapable of grasping the idea of a subatomic particle with a negative charge. My proposal, then, is that *Lovecraftian epistemological horror* is designed to horrify partly by depicting the possibility that there are fundamental features of reality that are perceptually or cognitively hidden from its characters.

Importantly, Lovecraftian epistemological horror fiction need not involve the supernatural. The idea that some features of reality are hidden from humans, cognitively or perceptually, is compatible with a thoroughly physicalist conception of reality—a conception of reality that Lovecraft himself embraced. As Eugene Thacker said in his study of Lovecraft's work, "What we call supernatural is simply another kind of nature but one that lies beyond human comprehension—not in a relative but in an absolute sense" (2011, 122). Of course, Lovecraftian epistemological

horror fiction is not exclusive to Lovecraft's work, or even to work that Lovecraft influenced. It seems to me that Algernon Blackwood's celebrated story "The Willows" is an instance of Lovecraftian epistemological horror fiction, despite the fact that Blackwood drew no inspiration from Lovecraft. Still, it is not inappropriate to name the subgenre after Lovecraft, since he is probably the subgenre's most prolific and influential practitioner.

One final clarification concerning the relationship between these varieties of epistemological horror. As I mentioned briefly in section II, they are not mutually exclusive. Lovecraft himself provides examples that fall into multiple categories, since many of his stories, including "From Beyond," involve the theme of forbidden knowledge and so can be regarded as Promethean epistemological horror. For him the destructive consequences of forbidden knowledge are often psychological in nature. The point is perhaps most famously stated in "The Call of Cthulhu," where the narrator predicts that "the piecing together of disassociated knowledge will open up such terrifying vistas of reality, and of our frightful position therein, that we shall either go mad from the revelation or flee from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age" (2008/1928, 355). It is also possible for a piece of fiction to count simultaneously as Promethean epistemological horror, Lovecraftian epistemological horror, and Cartesian epistemological horror.

V. THE VALUE OF HORROR

As I mentioned in section I, the philosophy of horror has been preoccupied with the paradox of horror (*why do people enjoy horror fiction?*), but I tend to agree with Berys Gaut (1993) and Philip Nickel (2010) that the paradox of horror raises an essentially psychological question rather than a philosophical one. This is not to say that philosophers have nothing to contribute to the discussion, but solving the paradox of horror will require a good deal of empirical investigation, falling outside

the traditional purview of philosophical inquiry. Furthermore, it should not be assumed that there is one uniform explanation of the pleasure that people derive from horror fiction. It might be that different people enjoy horror fiction for fundamentally different reasons.

As Nickel observed, philosophers should be more concerned with the question of whether horror fiction has *value*. Intriguingly, Nickel argues that horror fiction has distinctively epistemological value, independent of any aesthetic or moral value. On his view, the threats that characters confront in horror fiction are analogous to the threats that skeptical scenarios pose to our presumptions of knowledge. Just as the external world skeptic challenges us to rule out the possibility that we are brains in vats, horror fiction challenges us to rule out the possibility that our neighbors will become cannibalistic zombies, or that the birds in the sky will suddenly attack, or that the seemingly harmless hotel clerk is a serial murderer. These scenarios threaten the sense of security that we take for granted in "everyday life," inducing a state of unease that cannot be resolved through any rational means. Instead, it can only be resolved by returning to everyday life, which happens after exiting the theater, or putting down the book, and simply shaking off our fears. Nickel suggests that our own inevitable response to skepticism is similar. Our only escape from skeptical worries is to return to everyday life, shaking off those worries. As David Hume mused, "I dine, I play a game of back-gammon, I converse, and am merry with my friends; and when after three or four hour's amusement, I wou'd return to these speculations, they appear so cold, and strain'd, and ridiculous, that I cannot find in my heart to enter into them any farther" (2000/1739, 175). Horror fiction has epistemological value, according to Nickel, because it "helps us to see that a notion of everyday life completely secure against threats cannot be possible, and that the security of common sense is a persistent illusion" (2010, 17).

Nickel's account of the epistemological value of horror fiction is very general, extending to horror fiction that does not count as epistemological horror in any of the senses outlined above. One of his case studies is *The Birds*, which is not an instance of Promethean, Cartesian, or Lovecraftian epistemological horror. Though I think that the generality of his account is admirable, I worry that the account presupposes a defeatist attitude toward external world skepticism. It seems central to his account that horror fiction is valuable because it leads to a particular recognition—our ordinary sense of security is rationally unfounded just as our ordinary presumptions of knowledge are rationally unfounded. But this position is highly contestable. There have been many epistemologists who believe that our ordinary presumptions of knowledge are rationally defensible, so we need not respond to skepticism by merely returning to everyday life. Instead, we might respond by arguing that we can somehow rule out skeptical scenarios (Descartes 1996/1641), or that, even if we cannot decisively rule them out, skeptical scenarios are not the best explanations of our perceptual experiences and so we are justified in maintaining our ordinary beliefs about the external world (Russell 1912). These are just some of the many strategies that epistemologists have pursued against external world skepticism. As I said in section IV, our purpose is not to debate whether skepticism is correct, so I do not take any position on whether these strategies are successful. I mention them only to call into question the defeatist attitude that Nickel's account seems to presuppose.

It seems to me that if horror has epistemological value, then it is to be found in the subgenre of epistemological horror outlined here, and it consists mainly in encouraging us to reflect upon serious epistemological questions. Some of these questions concern skepticism—whether we can trust our perceptual experiences, whether there are certain features of the world that our perceptual experiences are incapable of representing, and so on. Other questions concern whether knowledge

is necessarily a good thing, or whether knowledge might constitute a sort of transgression. Just as there might be different reasons why horror is enjoyable, there might be different reasons why horror is epistemologically valuable, corresponding to the different varieties of epistemological horror. Of course, other genres can present epistemological questions, but horror might be particularly valuable because it can present these questions in a particularly gripping manner. This is because horror can elicit such potent affects, making these questions seem urgent rather than theoretical, and these affects can linger long after someone exits the theater or puts down the book. Days after watching *A Nightmare on Elm Street*, someone might still worry whether she is immersed in a dream that Freddy has conjured. She might scold herself for being childish and reassure herself that Freddy is not real—but then she might come to the grim realization that Freddy's victims probably thought the same thing before being eviscerated. And I submit that there is nothing like the prospect of evisceration to make someone want to know whether she is immersed in a dream.[11]

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[1] A few tangential points. First, Carroll often uses the term "art-horror" to describe both the relevant genre and the emotion that this genre is supposed to elicit. I tend to agree with Hick (2022) that this terminology is mostly unnecessary, so I dispense with it here. Second, Carroll focuses on horror fiction, understood broadly to include both literature and film, but he is open to the idea that other art forms fall into the genre. He mentions the paintings of Goya and drawings of Giger (1990, 12). We might also wonder whether the genre includes music, dance, and sculpture. Like Carroll and others, I focus on fiction, but it is an interesting question whether epistemological horror might be found in other art forms. Finally, Carroll holds that successful horror fiction horrifies indirectly, by virtue of the monster horrifying the characters in the fiction. So, one's emotional responses are meant to parallel the emotional responses of the characters to the monster. This is what I call "the Emotional Synchronization Thesis." There is much to be said in favor of the Emotional Synchronization Thesis, but it has limits. Rewatching the original *Halloween*, it is striking how often one is meant to be frightened by Michael Myers as he lurks in the background, even when the other characters are oblivious to his presence.

[2] Carroll's views on impurity are inspired by the pioneering work of Mary Douglas (1966).

[3] Hick's account might feel less than satisfactory without an answer to the question of what is held in common between the different affects that he mentions. I do not deny that Hick's account is less than satisfactory for this reason. Still, I accept it for the purposes of this essay. For, as I mentioned above, it seems to be descriptively adequate and I do not wish to be restricted to Carroll's account. I certainly do not take Hick to have provided the final word on the nature of horror. The matter deserves much more discussion.

[4] Note that the first category, concerning what should not be known, involves a normative element as well as an epistemological element. In this respect it is similar to other topics in epistemology that intersect with normative philosophy, such as whether there is any reason that one should seek knowledge rather than mere true belief (Pritchard, Turri, and Carter 2022), or whether there are distinctively epistemological forms of injustice (Fricker 2007).

[5] To use terminology that Carroll and Feagin both borrow from Gary Iseminger (1983), she prefers an "integrationist" solution to the paradox of horror rather than a "co-existentialist" solution. Note that Carroll (1992) responds directly to Feagin's worries.

[6] *The Last Drive-In* season 4 episode 1.

[7] To revisit a point that I mentioned briefly above, not every example of a genre needs to be a paradigmatic one. I do not insist that films such as *Hellraiser* and *Alien* are paradigmatic examples of Promethean epistemological horror. I am perhaps most comfortable saying that they have themes of the genre, even if these themes are not of central importance in these cases. Ultimately, I am sympathetic to a reviewer's suggestion that there are stronger and weaker senses in which something might count as "epistemological" horror, depending on how its epistemological theme is connected to its horrifying effects—the connection is tighter in some cases and looser in others. In any event, if the reader feels that I am reaching too far when I suggest certain examples, then feel free to focus on my discussion of paradigmatic examples of epistemological horror. Thanks to a reviewer for prompting me to address this point. It undoubtedly deserves even more discussion.

[8] Some epistemologists understand skeptical scenarios in such a way that the targeted belief (in this case, the belief that there is a coffee mug in front of me) is not necessarily false. Consider, for example, a scenario in which I am dreaming of a coffee mug in front of me and it turns out, as a matter of coincidence, that there actually *is* a coffee mug in front of me. Stroud (1984) and Moore (1959) discuss skeptical scenarios of this sort. For the sake of simplicity, I focus on skeptical scenarios in which the targeted belief is false. For a useful discussion of these different sorts of skeptical scenarios, see Murphy (2013).

[9] Note that even after invoking a skeptical scenario, the external world skeptic must devise an argument from the possibility that one's perceptual experiences are misleading to the conclusion that one does not know certain things about the external world. There are various arguments, relying on various epistemological principles, that a skeptic might devise. For a close examination of a canonical Cartesian skeptical argument, see Brueckner (1994).

[10] Here I am essentially rephrasing Colin McGinn's notion of "cognitive closure" (1984). McGinn argues that the solution to the Mind-Body Problem is cognitively closed to us. In the philosophy of religion, some skeptical theists can be understood as arguing that the solution to the Problem of Evil is cognitively closed to us (McBrayer 2024).

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